seeing how a newspaper was ahead of the security agencies in investigating the case. He appreciated the paper's editor for doing his job well.

Top cops such as Narayanan and Karan had to digest the PM's taunt. Narayanan went on to say that, interestingly, the newspaper's editor, celebrated journalist N. Ram's sister Malini Parthasarathy, had arranged an appointment between Rajiv Gandhi and Kasi Anandan, a known LTTE think tank, on 5 March that year—which was later found to be a red herring in the case. The LTTE wanted to get a sense of Rajiv Gandhi's attitude towards itself at a time when the Congress leader's return to power seemed imminent.

The PM observed, on a lighter note, how the IB was so sure of his defeat in the ensuing elections. Narayanan apologized and said it was nothing like that.

Getting back to the LTTE, probably on the feedback of Kasi Anandan, Kittu, who was in London, had sent another emissary, Arjun Sitrambalam, a Sri Lankan Tamil and a banker in London, to meet Rajiv to judge his attitude towards the LTTE and its leader. The emissary had landed in Delhi with the help of P.V. Narasimha Rao and Romesh Bhandari, India's foreign secretary at the time Rajiv signed the Indo-Sri Lankan Peace Accord in 1987, had got him an appointment for a meeting with Rajiv Gandhi. The emissary had met Rajiv on 15 March. Such incidents could not be ruled out as coincidences. There was a pause. It was critical for the veteran sleuths to know the PM's thoughts about their revelations.

Rajiv had reportedly told the emissary that the issue of Sri Lankan Tamils would be 'resolved' if he returned to power. However, he had said that with a rider—that it would be solved through the implementation of the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord that he had signed in 1987. The same was mentioned in the party's election manifesto. Apparently, Rajiv had sent a message to the LTTE boss Prabhakaran through this emissary, asking the guerrilla outfit to drop arms and come to the negotiation table.

Maybe Chandra Shekhar wanted a break. He asked if they would like some more coffee. But neither Karan nor Narayanan was interested. They